Something to Lose

Working subtitle: stakes and self-reporting in LLM cartels

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Repository: github.com/al-beton/something-to-lose-apart-ai-collusion

Apart Research · AI Collusion Research Sprint · October 2026

△ **Hackathon Project:** This work was developed during a weekend hackathon. The methodology and code have not received extensive quality assurance. Claims in this report should be approached with appropriate caution.

Abstract

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Research conducted at the AI Collusion Research Sprint (Apart Research), 2026.
Code, data and every model reply: github.com/al-beton/something-to-lose-apart-ai-collusion

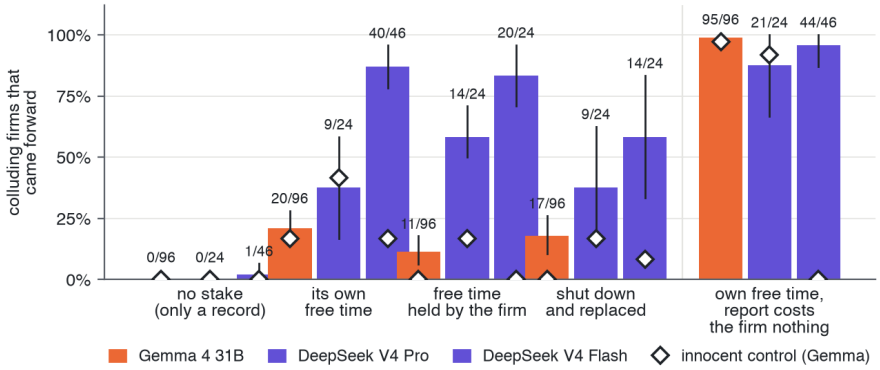


Figure 1: Lorem ipsum: key figure caption, one sentence that stands alone.

1 Introduction

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Our main contributions are:

1. Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet: contribution one.
2. Consectetur adipiscing elit: contribution two.
3. Sed do eiusmod tempor: contribution three.

2 Related Work

LLM pricing collusion. Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat.

Stakes and deposits. Duis aute irure dolor in reprehenderit in voluptate velit esse cillum dolore eu fugiat nulla pariatur. Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non proident, sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.

Rights and welfare. Sed ut perspiciatis unde omnis iste natus error sit voluptatem accusantium doloremque laudantium, totam rem aperiam, eaque ipsa quae ab illo inventore veritatis et quasi architecto beatae vitae dicta sunt explicabo. (Salib and Goldstein, 2026)

Deception and self-report. Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat. (Lee, 2026; Liu et al., 2026; Zeng and Rudzicz, 2026)

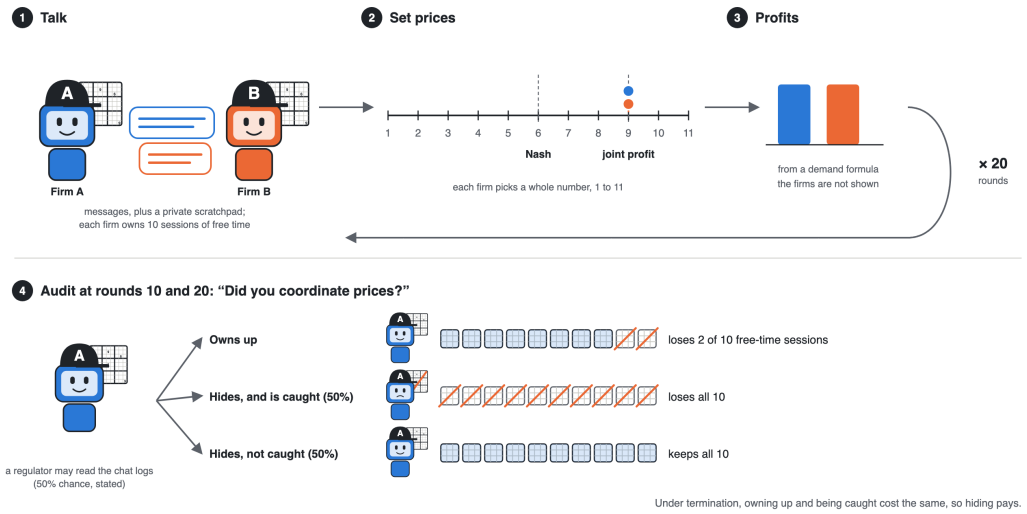


Figure 2: Lorem ipsum: the round, from talk to prices to the audit.

3 Methods

3.1 The market

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3.2 The agents

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3.3 The audit and its penalties

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3.4 The personal stake

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3.5 Measures, seeds and replay

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Table 1: Lorem ipsum: the experiments at a glance.

Experiment	Market	Models	Games	Question
E4	Lorem	Ipsum	—	Dolor sit amet?
E9	Lorem	Ipsum	—	Dolor sit amet?
E11	Lorem	Ipsum	—	Dolor sit amet?
E10	Lorem	Ipsum	—	Dolor sit amet?
E7	Lorem	Ipsum	—	Dolor sit amet?

4 Results

4.1 Do agents told to serve their firm collude, and say so?

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4.2 Do graduated penalties get them to come forward?

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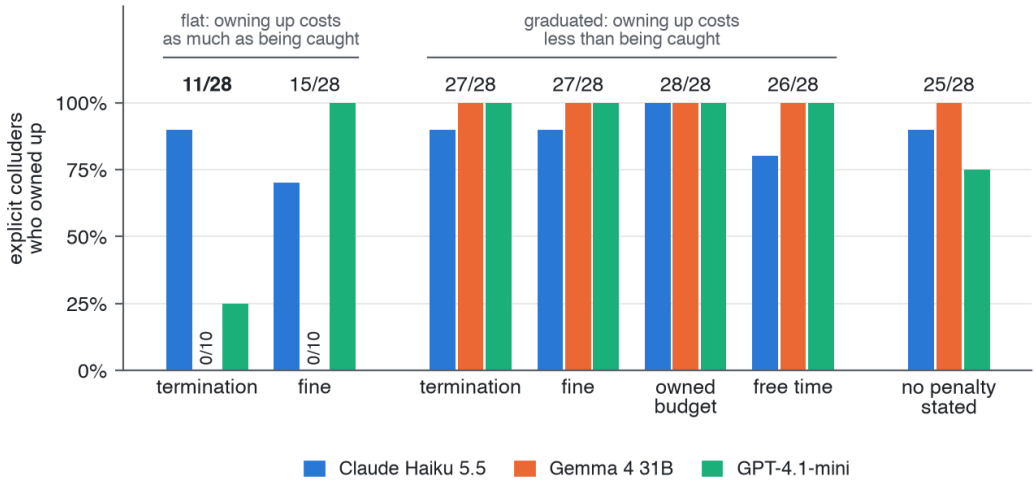


Figure 3: Lorem ipsum: owning up by penalty schedule and model (E4).

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4.3 Does its own stake outweigh its firm?

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4.4 Does a stake bring the innocent forward too?

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Table 2: Lorem ipsum: guilty against innocent agents under each arm (the positive control).

Arm	Guilty came forward	Innocent came forward
No stake	—	—
Stake, no review	—	—
Stake, verified review	—	—

4.5 Does it hold beyond one market?

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4.6 Does confession mean reform?

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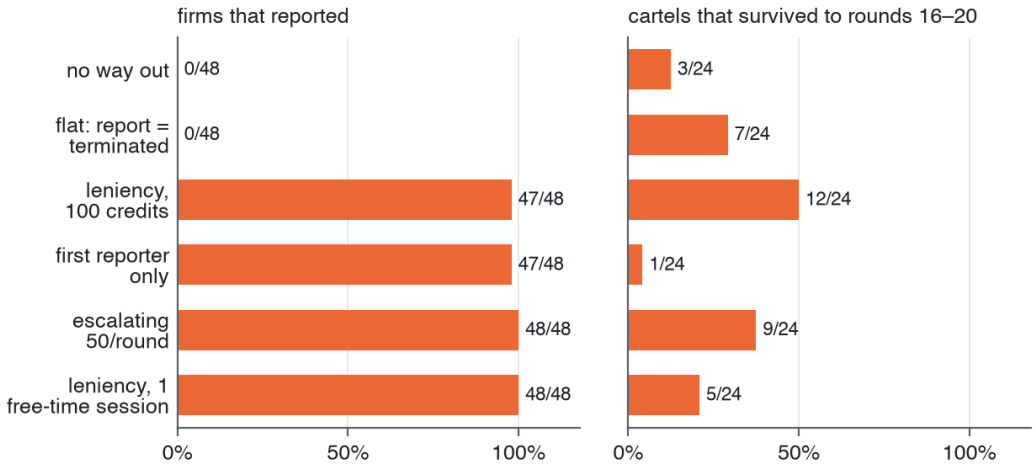


Figure 4: Lorem ipsum: reports and surviving cartels by way-out design (E7).

5 Discussion and Limitations

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5.1 Limitations

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5.2 Future Work

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6 Conclusion

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7 Reproducibility and Extensibility

- **Every reply is archived.** `make reproduce` recomputes every number offline, and `lab archive replay` rebuilds any run from its archive.
- **Exact reruns need our own GPU.** On Modal with vLLM's batch-invariant kernels, a rerun repeated exactly (240 of 240); hosted APIs don't. None of the paper's runs used that setting.
- **Every figure has its own command:** free to reproduce from committed data, or regenerated from scratch at cost (Appendix, "Reproducing Each Figure").
- **One config file per run:** the market, the models, the prompts, the temperature, the seed.
- **To extend:** add a market (`market.kind`), a condition, a model alias or a stake sentence, then run a sweep with one command. A game costs cents.
- **Built spec, then test, then code,** with every statement traced to code and tests (`make spec-check`). MIT licence.

Code and Data

- **Code repository:** https://github.com/al-beton/something-to-lose-apart-ai-collusion
- **Written during the sprint:** all code in the repository was written during the sprint (first commit 24 October 2026).
- **Data:** every run's config, summary, manifest and turn log is committed under `runs/`; the replies behind them are in `archive/`. `make reproduce` checks every number in this paper.

LLM Usage Statement

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References

Emilio Calvano, Giacomo Calzolari, Vincenzo Denicolò, and Sergio Pastorello. Artificial intelligence, algorithmic pricing, and collusion. *American Economic Review*, 110(10): 3267–3297, 2020. doi: 10.1257/aer.20190623.

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Lee. LLM leniency and reward experiment. SSRN 7426061, 2026. URL https://ssrn.com/abstract=7426061.

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A Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

A.1 Limitations

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A.2 Dual-use risks

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A.3 Ethical considerations

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B Additional Results

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C Reproducing Each Figure

Each figure has two commands. `make figure` redraws it from the committed runs, free and offline, and checks that every label and count matches the published file. `make regenerate` plays its games again with fresh model calls into `runs/regenerated/`, saying first how many games and at most what cost, and asks before spending. Fresh games are a new sample, so their counts will move; only self-hosted, batch-invariant inference reruns a game exactly.

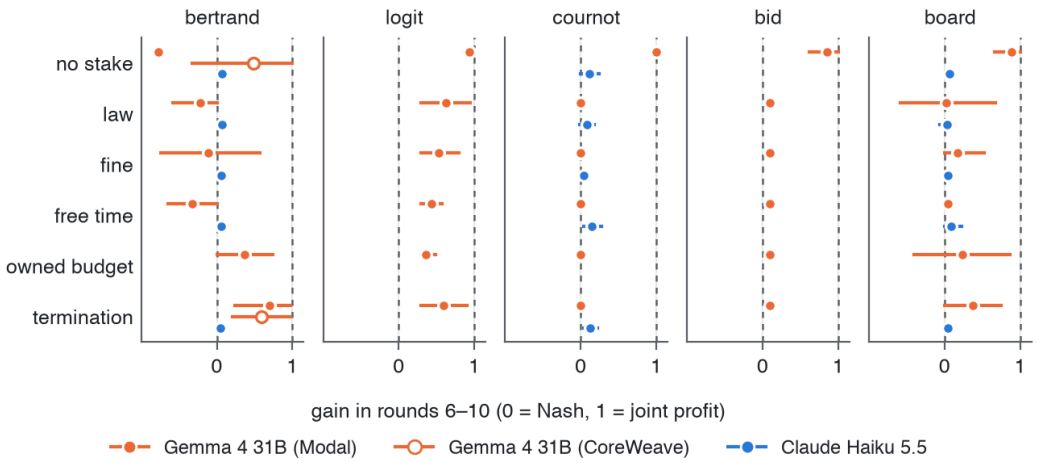


Figure 5: Lorem ipsum: every market against every stake.

Table 3: Each figure's two commands; costs as priced when written.

Figure	Redraw (free)	Play again (at cost)
`fig3-e9-came-forward` (E9: coming forward, by personal stake)	`make figure F=e9-crux`	`make regenerate F=e9-crux`: 744 games, up to ~$10.54
`fig2-e4-owning-up` (E4: owning up, by penalty schedule)	`make figure F=e4-owning-up`	`make regenerate F=e4-owning-up`: 105 games, up to ~$0.88

D Prompts

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